

CASE ID: 199505710002

EPISODE NAME: US-China Third Taiwan Strait Crisis

1995/05/23 - 1996/03/23

Sender: China (710)

Target: United States (2)

Issue: Contain Political Influence (1)

Final Outcome: Stalemate after Sanctions Imposition (9)

Summary:

On 1995/05/23, the Chinese foreign ministry threatened the United States with diplomatic sanctions after the Clinton Administration approved Taiwanese president Lee Teng-hui's travel visa to the U.S.¹ When the US did not revoke Lee's visa, China cancelled multiple state visits²³⁴⁵ and conducted military exercises near Taiwan between 1995/07/19 and 1996/03/23⁶⁷⁸. The episode ended on 1996/03/23, when Lee won the Taiwanese presidential election, and China scaled down its pressure campaign.⁹

Narrative:

On 1995/05/23, the Chinese foreign ministry threatened that allowing Taiwanese president Lee Teng-hui to enter the United States would "inevitably cause severe damage to Sino-US relations."¹⁰ The vague threat was issued in response to the Clinton Administration's decision – under pressure from Congress – to allow Lee to attend his university reunion at Cornell on 1995/06/09.¹¹ Beijing had successfully pressured the US into recognizing the People's Republic of China as the sole government of China in 1979 and considered Lee to be illegitimate.¹²

¹ Tyler, Patrick. "China Demands US Cancel Visit by Taiwan's President." *New York Times*, 23 May 1995.

² "China cancels official visits, pressing U.S. to deny visa to The United States." *The Sun*, 27 May 1995.

³ Tempest, Rone. "China Threatens U.S. over Taiwan Leader's Visit : Diplomacy: Beijing Recalls Two Delegations, Vows Further Action over Perceived Nod to Taipei." *Los Angeles Times*, Los Angeles Times, 26 May 1995, www.latimes.com/archives/la-xpm-1995-05-26-mn-6275-story.html.

⁴ "China Halts Arms Talks with US." *The Boston Globe*, 29 May 1995.

⁵ "China recalls ambassador to US." *The Boston Globe*, 17 June 1995.

⁶ Mufson, Stephen. "China to Conduct Military Expedition Near Taiwan." *The Washington Post*, 18 July 1995.

⁷ Beal, Thom. "China Announces New Missile Tests." *UPI*, 10 Aug. 1995, www.upi.com/Archives/1995/08/10/China-announces-new-missile-tests/6871808027200/.

⁸ Tempest, Rone. "China Says It Will End Maneuvers as Planned." *Los Angeles Times*, 15 March 1996, www.latimes.com/archives/la-xpm-1996-03-15-mn-47379-story.html.

⁹ Ibid.

¹⁰ Tyler, Patrick. "China Demands US Cancel Visit by Taiwan's President." *New York Times*, 23 May 1995.

¹¹ Greenhouse, Stephen. "Aides to Clinton Say He Will Defy Beijing and Issue Visa to Taiwan's President." *New York Times*, 22 May 1995.

<https://www.nytimes.com/1995/05/22/world/aides-to-clinton-say-he-will-defy-beijing-and-issue-visa-to-taiwan-s-president.html>.

¹² Ibid.

After the US failed to revoke Lee's visa, China imposed a series of escalating diplomatic sanctions. On 1995/05/26, China recalled two diplomatic delegations.¹³ A day later, they postponed a trip to the US by Chinese defense minister Chi Haotian scheduled for 1995/06.¹⁴ Most significantly, China halted negotiations over Chinese arms sales to the Middle East on 1995/05/28.¹⁵ Beijing also briefly recalled its ambassadors directly after Lee's visit.¹⁶

Beginning on 1995/07/18, China began conducting military exercises in the East China Sea near Taiwan.¹⁷ Although the US became involved, China's military coercion may have been directed at destabilizing Lee's government more than targeting the US.¹⁸ Beijing concluded its military exercises on 1996/03/23, after Lee won reelection.¹⁹ Reporting suggests the US never agreed to stop issuing visas to top Taiwanese officials.²⁰

¹³ Tempest, Rone. "China Threatens U.S. over Taiwan Leader's Visit : Diplomacy: Beijing Recalls Two Delegations, Vows Further Action over Perceived Nod to Taipei." *Los Angeles Times*, Los Angeles Times, 26 May 1995, www.latimes.com/archives/la-xpm-1995-05-26-mn-6275-story.html.

¹⁴ "China cancels official visits, pressing U.S. to deny visa to The United States." *The Sun*, 27 May 1995.

¹⁵ "China Halts Arms Talks with US." *The Boston Globe*, 29 May 1995.

¹⁶ "China recalls ambassador to US." *The Boston Globe*, 17 June 1995.

¹⁷ Mufson, Stephen. "China to Conduct Military Expedition Near Taiwan." *The Washington Post*, 18 July 1995.

¹⁸ Lawrence, Susan and Wayne Morrison. *Taiwan: Issues for Congress*. Congressional Research Service, R44996, 30 Oct. 2017. <https://sgp.fas.org/crs/row/R44996.pdf>.

¹⁹ Tempest, Rone. "China Says It Will End Maneuvers as Planned." *Los Angeles Times*, 15 March 1996, www.latimes.com/archives/la-xpm-1996-03-15-mn-47379-story.html.

²⁰ "U.S., China hold talks." *Tampa Bay Times*, 2 August, 1995. <https://www.tampabay.com/archive/1995/08/02/u-s-china-hold-talks/>.